

FBI Phoenix Division Field Office

201 E. Indianola Ave., Phoenix, AZ

1997



Figure 1: North-West corner (main entrance) - 2023 Business Journal street shot, but little has changed: same copper ventilation spine and the entry ramp that agents would have walked through in 1997.

1 | Setting on the Street Grid

East Indianola Avenue is a quiet two-lane street that runs east–west one block south of the busier Indian School Road. The FBI lot comprises roughly the Eastern half of the block bounded by East Indianola Avenue (to the north), North 2nd Street (to the west), North 3rd Street (to the East) and East Clarendon Avenue (to the south)¹. Surroundings are a 1970s medical-office cluster: low cactus beds, surface parking, and the brown-glass mid-rise of St. Joseph’s Hospital a few blocks south-west. Central Avenue’s skyline pokes up in the background towards the west.

Immediate neighbours:

- North: a paved but mostly empty lot used on weekends by an A/C contractor to store white Chevy vans.
- West: a one-story law-office bungalow with a sagging tile roof.
- East: a three-story beige concrete IRS Annex.
- South alley: chain-link fence, dumpsters, and the stairwell exhaust vents that blow warm printer-toner smell into the dusk.

2 | Exterior Architecture

Era & lineage: Built 1972 as a respiratory-care hospital, the red-brick, L-shaped structure was purchased by the General Services Administration in 1984, gutted, and re-opened as the FBI’s permanent Phoenix Division in 1986. (Hence the oddly wide corridors - former gurney width.) Note that the property has had several addresses through the years: 201 E. Indianola (FBI mail address 1986-2001), 40 E. Indianola (commercial parcel number used by GSA after FBI moved out), and 2171 N. Central / 21711 sign (decorative campus number added after 2012).

Dimensions: Four floors above ground, basement (B1) and sub-basement (B2). Roughly 180 ft × 150 ft footprint; tallest point 55 ft. A copper-coloured metal ventilation spine bisects the north-west façade from sidewalk to roof parapet - visible in most photos (see above).

¹ On modern (May 2026) maps, the L-shaped building that hosted the FBI in 1997 is inconsistently marked: on openstreetmap.org the building is marked as ‘BASIS Phoenix Central’ while on maps.google.com it is an unmarked building immediately to the West of a building marked as ‘CO+HOOTS Coworking | Phoenix’ and ‘CPR Certification Phoenix’ (note: in 1997, this is the site of the IRS Annex mentioned in Section 2).

Skin & roof: Flame-brick cladding; strip-windows of bronze reflective glass; white elastomeric roof dotted with two rooftop chillers, three microwave dishes, and a simple painted “H” square – technically not a helipad but used for emergency airlift drills.

Landscaping: Two mature Aleppo pines and a pair of broad ficus trees frame the main entry; desert spiny lizard (“Mister Blue”) basks on the planter blocks from mid-morning, and only retreats during the hottest part of the afternoon. A low brick ramp leads to glass double doors; the DoJ/FBI seal is the only signage.



Figure 2: Mister Blue

3 | Security Envelope

Parking: 68 paved spaces inside a knee-high brick wall (Petrovic has been fighting GSA² for two years to get bollards installed after Oklahoma City); no gate in '97 - just a painted “RESERVED: FEDERAL GOVT” stencil. Agents reverse-park habitually for fast egress.

Cameras & lights: Two black-and-white Pelco CCTV domes cover the lobby doors; sodium-vapour (yellowish-brown light) lamp poles ring the lot. No perimeter fence - security starts at the lobby.

Entry routine:

- Glass vestibule → mag-stripe badge swipe + four-digit PIN.
- X-ray tunnel and magnetometer supervised by Federal Protective Service guard.
- Weapon-clearing barrel to the right of the podium; mandatory before visiting the evidence vault.

4 | Interior Floor-by-Floor

Level	Principal rooms & functions	NPCs often found here
1st Floor (ground level)	• Public lobby & screening (magnetometer/X-ray) 100 • Reception / Public-Affairs desk 101 • Polygraph suite 121A (sound-proof, one-way glass) • Interview rooms 140-142 • Admin bay (budget, payroll, travel) 150-164 • Bullpen: Violent-Crime squad 170-179 • Break-room 195 & vending-alcove • Secure conference 130 (“the Fish-bowl”)	• Violent-Crime team • Civil-Rights team • lobby guards
2nd Floor	• SAC office 200 (NW corner) • ASAC offices 210-212 (Ortiz, Petrovic) • USAO liaison cubicle 216 • Public-Corruption & White-Collar cubicles 220-248 • Computer-forensics workroom • Large conference rooms 260/262 • File-prep staging room 270	
3rd Floor	• Counterintelligence bullpen 310-318 (quiet side) • Organized Crime / Narcotics squad case room 330 • Computer Analysis Response Team (CART) examiner station (single desk) • Radio/Surveillance tech shop 350 • Roof-access stair & antenna patch • Restrooms / kitchenette	
4th Floor	• Training auditorium 401 • Physical-fitness gym & mat room 410	

2 General Services Administration – the federal agency that handles the government’s “back office” real estate and procurement work.

	• SWAT ready-room / locker bay 420 • Emergency operations centre 430 (war-room overflow)	
Roof	• Microwave dishes • Painted “H” for helicopter hoist / rappel drills (training only, not FAA authorisation for actual landings) • Curve-billed thrasher “Ace” roost ledge	
Basement (B1)	• Loading dock & freight elevator landing • Mail Cage B105 • Supply Cage B110 • Evidence Vault B120 + Evidence-Control office • Photo Lab & dark-room B130 • ERT kit storage racks B140 • Custodian closet / day-locker B150 • Telecom rack-room spur	
Sub-Basement (B2)	• Weapons Vault & Armorer shop B205 • SWAT & ERT gear cage overflow B210 • File stacks / archive runners’ track B220 • Mechanical/HVAC plant & boilers B230 • Generator & fuel farm room B240 • Telecom main frame & CSU-DSU B250 • Sub-floor access corridors	

Elevators: Two 3,500-lb Dover cars, wood-panel interiors, habitually slow. Policy note: after 23:00, agents must badge into stairwells - elevators automatically park at ground and lock.

5 | Critical Rooms Every Agent Knows

Bullpen Coffee Nook. Bunn brewer, mini-fridge, corkboard of Dilbert strips.

Ops Conference (Room 260). Windowless, U-shaped table, multi-line Polycom speakerphone, Kodak slide projector.

Polygraph Suite (121A). Wood-paneled, Luft-type high-back chair, one-way mirror. A faint whiff of nervous sweat permeates the upholstery.

Photo Darkroom. Red safelight, twin 35 mm dip tanks, and an ancient Beseler enlarger. Tech Bill Ames flicks the safelight during punchlines.

Supply Cage (Basement B110). Chain-link walls, smell of toner and cardboard; Phyllis Chang rules it like Fort Knox - no new legal pads without the spent back cover.

Evidence Vault (“The Bank”). Bank-style round steel door, time-lock disabled at 07:00, relocked 18:00. Sue Hightower guards FD-192 logs like scripture.

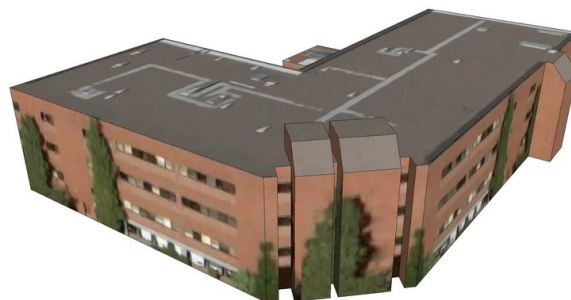


Figure 3: Google Sketch-Up model built from 2007 aerials; North-west corner.

6 | Traffic Patterns & Ambient Life

Morning (07:30–09:00). Agents stream from parking lot through lobby, jacketed; “Ace” the curve-billed thrasher nesting on the roof belts his chi-CA-go cry from the rooftop gutter.

Mid-day (11:30). Courier vans idle curbside; Chip the vending-tech is swapping out expired Snickers; Nana Rose the calico weaves under G-ride bumpers looking for shade.

Evening (17:00+). Custodian Dee mops down the corridor; hallway smells briefly of Pine-Sol; elevators dings echo on nearly empty floors.



Figure 4: South-facing courtyard entry (c. 2016). This was the ambulance bay when the structure was a hospital - useful if agents have to bring prisoners or evidence in the back way.

7 | Squads & the Chain-of-Command

The Phoenix Division is commanded by the Special Agent in Charge (SAC) and his Assistant Special Agents in Charge (ASAC). Together they form the Front Office. Big offices (New York, Los Angeles, Washington DC, etc.) may be led by an Assistant Director in Charge (ADIC), but most field offices are headed by a SAC, Phoenix Division among them. Active field agents are arranged into squads of specific focus areas, each of them lead by a Supervisory Special Agent (SSA). Any other (non-supervisory) agent is a Special Agent (SA), regardless of speciality (rookie SAs usually do not have a speciality yet, but they are still SAs) Experienced SAs may in some cases be designated as case agents / lead case agents, meaning they will be lead investigators on major or complex cases, but it's a functional role rather than a hierarchical position, and case agents are peers to other SAs.

The squads currently in operation in the summer of 1997 are:

- Violent Crime Squad / Gang Unit
- Organized Crime / Narcotics Squad
- White Collar Crime / Squad (incl. fraud / public Corruption)
- National Security Squad (incl. counterintelligence / counterterrorism)

8 | Agents Roster, Everyday Cast

These are FBI agents whom the PCs are likely to encounter on a daily basis at the 201 E. Indianola Ave. office (arranged from top of the chain of command downward.)

Phoenix Division Front Office (Command):

Name / Age	Role	Location	Appearance & Personality	Idiosyncrasies / Quirks
William "Bill" Lechner, 52	Special Agent in Charge (SAC) - the single executive for the whole division	2nd Floor, Northwest corner office (large window, Arizona flag, locked credenza)	Crisp Ivy-League suit, silver crew-cut, laconic.	Keeps a Lucite baseball signed by Willie Mays on his credenza; touches it when pondering big decisions.
Sandra K. Ortiz, 47	Assistant SAC – Criminal Programs (violent crime, drugs, fugitive, civil-rights squads)	2nd Floor, office adjacent to SAC	Former NYPD detective; favours bright silk scarves, blunt feedback.	Carries a brass New York subway token in her blazer pocket as a lucky charm.
Daniel "Dan" Petrovic,	Assistant SAC –	2nd Floor, office	Soft-spoken bean-	Known for surprise

45	Administration & Support (budget, facilities, IT)	adjacent to SAC	counter type; wears suspenders and owns an antique abacus “for stress relief.”	hallway fire-drills.
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Violent Crime Squad / Gang Unit (your squad):

Name / Age	Role	Location	Appearance & Personality	Idiosyncrasies / Quirks
Charles “Chuck” Brody, 43	Supervisory Special Agent (SSA)	Desk #170, 1st Floor bullpen, corner cubicle with sliding frosted-glass panel	Ex-Marine MP; gravel voice, red pen always clipped to shirt pocket.	Doodles tactical flow-charts on coffee filters during phone calls.
Daniel “Danny” Vega, 38	(Senior) SA	Desk #171	Barrel-chested ex-Marine; gold wedding band on a shoelace around his neck (“safer than a finger in a fight”). Loud belly-laugh that carries across partitions.	Doodles elaborate surfboards on legal pads when interviewing robbery witnesses.
Paul Burke, 34	SA	Desk #172, across the aisle from Daniel Vega	Cropped auburn hair, ex-Amtrak police.	“Fixes” the coffee maker with a Swiss-Army knife whenever it sputters.
Stanley “Stan” Kim, 27	SA	Desk #173 beside Paul	Rookie-eager Korean-American; always wearing neon-yellow earplugs at the range to “save hearing for old age.”	Keeps a laminated index card in his breast pocket with the Miranda warning printed on it; <u>brings</u> homemade kimchi in Tupperware for lunch roughly twice a week
Frank DeSoto, 36	SA	Desk #174, opposite Danny Vega	Straight-arrow former DPS trooper; keeps a stack of blank FD-302s pre-paper-clipped to save seconds.	Won't swear. Not even mild stuff. His strongest expletive is "for crying out loud," and the squad has a small running pool on what it would actually take to break him.
James “Jimmy” Longoria, 32	SA	Desk #175, facing the fax machine	South-Texas drawl, neatly parted hair.	Writes block-caps in field notebook.
Jack “Breaker” Norwood, 36	SA - often takes lead on bank-robbery & armoured-car stick-ups	Desk #176	Compact, square-jawed; favours rolled-sleeve white shirts and calm drill-instructor voice	Snaps a fresh stick of chalk before mapping every heist on the squad room blackboard - “clean slate, fresh mind.”
Elena “Flare” Martinez, 29	SA - arson & serial-fire-spree specialist - has been to ATF arson school	Desk #177	Athletic build, dark braid; quick grin that vanishes in interview rooms; carries the scent of smoke test kits	Clicks a Zippo open-shut when she’s thinking; swears she can “smell” accelerants through drywall.

You will also encounter agents from the other squads (not listed here) on a daily basis.

9 | Day-to-Day Management & Chain-of-Command

“Know who can sign your overtime, and life gets easier.” - SSA Chuck Brody

Tier 1 – Front Office / Division Command:

Level	Who	What They Control	When You See Them
SAC	William “Bill” Lechner	Everything: strategy, press, politics	Major cases, career-day pep talks, or when things go nuclear
ASAC (Criminal Programs)	Sandra K. Ortiz	All investigative squads & tactical ops	Wire-tap approvals ³ , SWAT call-outs, “why is this case still open?”
ASAC (Admin & Support)	Daniel “Dan” Petrovic	Budget, facilities, IT, evidence, HR	New cars, broken elevators, travel-voucher audits

Tier 2 – Squad Leaders:

Squad	Supervisory Special Agent (SSA)
Violent-Crime	Charles “Chuck” Brody
Organized Crime	Andrew “Andy” Wood (dual-hatted w/ DEA)
White-Collar	Howard “Howie” McBride
National Security	Carol Schmidt

Rule of Thumb: Your SSA controls your schedule, approves your affidavits, and owns your mistakes. Everything bigger than that rolls up to one of the ASACs.

Tier 3 – Specialized Support (dual-reporting):

Unit	Operational Chain	Budget Chain
Evidence-Response Team (ERT) – Pete Novak	ASAC Ortiz	ASAC Petrovic
SWAT / Firearms – Leonard “Tex” Cartwright (with Armorer Terry Anders)	ASAC Ortiz	ASAC Petrovic
Radio & Surveillance Tech, CART Lab, Range Staff	Respective Squad SSA	ASAC Petrovic

How it affects play:

- Case calls: Ask your SSA.
- Overtime or leave: SSA → Petrovic’s admin bay.
- Flash-bang requisition: SSA → Ortiz → Tex.

Stay inside that ladder and you’ll never get blindsided in a staff meeting.

10 | A note on agent age – why the Phoenix field office roster skews 29+ years

Hiring age floor is 23 – candidates must be at least 23 (and under 37) on the day they report to Quantico. Even a “young-gun” rookie has already finished a four-year degree and met the Bureau’s experience requirements before they’ll touch them.

In 1997, candidates enter through one of several Entry Programs, each with its own prerequisites:

- Law Program – JD from an accredited law school (typically 25 at the earliest, given college + three years of law school).
- Accounting Program – bachelor’s in accounting plus CPA certification or equivalent (typically 24–25 with the work hours needed to sit for the CPA).
- Language Program – bachelor’s plus demonstrated fluency in a critical-needs language; experience requirement reduced.
- Engineering / Science Program – bachelor’s in a hard science or engineering discipline; experience requirement reduced.
- Diversified Program – bachelor’s in any field plus three years of full-time professional work experience (police, military, teaching, business, etc.). This is the catch-all path most generalists take.

³ Note that Title III intercepts/wiretaps need DoJ and then federal district court order to be authorised; Ortiz signs off internally before the application goes up to DoJ Main Justice for authorisation, then to court.

A master's degree can offset one year of the Diversified Program's three-year experience requirement, but the 23-year minimum age is hard. So a 22-year-old bachelor's graduate, even a brilliant one, simply has to wait.

Mid-30s "new" agents are normal; the Bureau prizes maturity and prior careers over raw youth. A career-changing 34-year-old former prosecutor, Army captain, or detective is a more typical New Agent profile than a 23-year-old straight off the experience floor.

Field offices often discourage placing multiple first-tour agents on the same high-tempo squad - experience matters, and a Violent Crime / Gang squad is no place to stack rookies.

Agents five years out of Quantico are still considered "young" by Bureau culture - rookies until they've testified in federal court, worked a wire, and written affidavits solo.

You could conceivably have 26- or 27-year-old probationary agents in rare cases (bachelor's at 22 + three years of qualifying work, reporting to Quantico the week they turn 23), but anyone markedly younger would violate 1997 policy unless they came in through the Law, Accounting, or specialty tracks - and even then, they'd hit Quantico at 25-26 and graduate at 26.

Quick reference, active field agents' ages:

Pipeline checkpoint	Typical age window (1997)
College graduation	21-22
Three years qualifying work (Diversified), or specialty-track equivalent	24-26
Quantico New Agent Training (16 weeks)	24-26
First field office tour	25-27
"Comfortable running own cases"	29-31

So the Phoenix bullpen feeling "late-twenties and up" isn't an accident - it mirrors how the Bureau staffs its squads.

11 | “Just an Agent” - How Specialization Really Works in 1997

The Bureau hires every new Special Agent as a generalist investigator first. No résumé comes stamped “computer-crime lead” or “aviation liaison” on Day 1. Those labels evolve after Quantico - often as collateral duties tacked on to a core assignment once the agent proves competence or reveals a pre-existing skill. So, the bullpen always holds a mix of these:

Career stage	What they’re called internally	Typical look in 1997 Phoenix
Probationary SA (first 2 years)	“New-Agent” or “GS-10”	Rotates through two or three squads; handles bread-and-butter interviews, surveillance logs, search-warrant affidavits. No fancy title beyond case agent.
Journeyman SA (years 3-7)	“Street agent”	Assigned permanently to one squad. May volunteer for one collateral - evidence-response, firearms instructor, brief SWAT stint - but still spends 80 % of time on general casework.
Subject-matter point	“Squad lead for X”	Happens organically: squad notices Jenkins is a UNIX nerd, Cartwright shoots perfect 300s, Novak loves plaster-casting shoe prints. They become the go-to in that lane while staying a line agent.
Formal specialty track	“Program Agent” (e.g., aviation, polygraph, undercover coordinator)	Requires extra Quantico courses and HQ certification; still holds the SA badge, but their collateral grows to 50 %+ of workload.
Management	SSA, ASAC, SAC	Off the street and into paperwork - but they once walked the same generalist path.

Key take-aways:

- Generalist first, niche later. New agents prove they can handle interviews, affidavits, and courtroom testimony before anyone hands them a specialty patch.

- Collateral ≠ full-time. Even Tex Cartwright (firearms instructor) spends most mornings running leads or drafting search warrants; he teaches the range once or twice a month.
- Specialties emerge from need. A squad that suddenly gets a string of computer-intrusion complaints will crown the first tech-savvy agent “computer-crime lead.” Nothing official, just pragmatism.
- Career progression. By the 5-year mark nearly everyone has something extra - evidence response, undercover certified, language asset - because it helps at promotion boards.

12 | The GS Ladder for Special Agents (1997)

FBI Special Agents are paid on the federal General Schedule (GS), with locality adjustments. Career progression is largely automatic for non-supervisory agents, assuming satisfactory performance:

Grade	Stage	Typical timing
GS-10	New Agent at Quantico through first field office tour	Years 0–1
GS-11	Probationary SA, end of first year	Year 1
GS-12	Journeyman SA	Year 2
GS-13	Journeyman SA – the career grade for street agents	Year 4 onward, indefinitely

Each GS grade is divided into 10 steps, representing longevity within that grade. Step increases come automatically with satisfactory performance – 1 year between Steps 1–4, 2 years between Steps 4–7, 3 years between Steps 7–10. A full climb from Step 1 to Step 10 takes 18 years. When an agent promotes to a new grade, they reset to a low step in the new grade (typically Step 1 or 2). So a "GS-13 Step 5" has been a journeyman agent for roughly 6–8 years; a "GS-13 Step 1" just got there last week.

GS-13 is the ceiling for non-supervisory agents. A street agent can spend their entire 20-year career at GS-13 and retire there – and many do, by choice. Going higher means going into management.

Grade	Role
GS-14	Supervisory Special Agent (SSA) – squad leader
GS-15	ASAC, Unit Chief at HQ
SES (Senior Executive Service – a separate personnel system that sits above the GS scale, as per the Civil Service Reform Act of 1978)	SAC, ADIC, and above

Practical implications for play:

- Brody (SSA) is a GS-14. Vega, Burke, DeSoto, Longoria, Norwood and Martinez are all GS-13s – peers on paper, regardless of seniority or "case agent" status.
- Stan Kim at 27 is the squad's only true rookie – still on probation, GS-11, still getting his FD-302s line-edited by Brody before they hit the file. The neon earplugs and the laminated Miranda card aren't quirks so much as the habits of an agent who is acutely aware that one rookie mistake can torpedo a case on cross-examination.
- Promotion to GS-14 requires applying for a supervisory posting, which usually means leaving Phoenix for HQ or another field office. The Bureau's "up or out" culture for management means an SSA who wants to make ASAC will likely have to relocate at least once more.
- Pay difference between GS-13 and GS-14 in 1997 Phoenix is real but not life-changing – roughly \$10K/year. Most street agents who stay GS-13 do so because they like the work, not because they couldn't pass the boards.

Grade	Step 1 base salary (effective January 1997)
GS-10	\$32,571
GS-11	\$35,786
GS-12	\$42,890
GS-13	\$51,003
GS-14	\$60,270
GS-15	\$70,894

Two adjustments apply on top of base for FBI agents in 1997 Phoenix:

- Locality pay: Locality adjustments started in 1994. In 1997, Phoenix wasn't one of the named major-metro localities (those were places like NYC, LA, SF, DC), so Phoenix agents would have received the "Rest of US" locality adjustment, which was roughly 4–5% in 1997. Add that to base.
- Law Enforcement Availability Pay (LEAP): This is the big one for FBI roster purposes. LEAP was enacted in 1994 specifically for federal criminal investigators (1811 series), and it adds a flat 25% of base + locality to compensate for the unscheduled overtime agents are expected to work. Every Special Agent on your roster is collecting LEAP unless they're on light duty.

Practical 1997 take-home for your roster (base + ~4% locality + 25% LEAP, approximate):

Agent	Grade/Step (likely)	Annual gross
Stan Kim (GS-11, just promoted)	GS-11 Step 1	~\$46,500
Vega, DeSoto, Burke, Longoria, Norwood, Martinez, O'Neill, Lentz (journeyman GS-13s, varying steps based on years)	GS-13 Step 3–5	~\$70,000–\$75,000
Bishop (senior GS-13, more time in grade)	GS-13 Step 5–6	~\$75,000–\$77,000
Brody (SSA, GS-14)	GS-14 Step 4–5	~\$86,000–\$89,000
Ortiz, Petrovic (ASACs, GS-15)	GS-15 Step 5–6	~\$104,000–\$107,000
Lechner (SAC)	SES (off-scale)	~\$115,000–\$125,000

A couple of notes that might matter at the table:

- GS-13 is genuinely comfortable money in 1997 Phoenix. Median household income in Phoenix in 1997 was around \$32,000. A GS-13 Step 5 agent grossing ~\$75K was solidly upper-middle-class, and could afford a decent house in the suburbs on one income. Your player characters are doing fine financially.
- The LEAP bargain. In exchange for that 25%, agents are expected to be available for an average of two extra hours per workday and to work whatever hours the case demands without further overtime. So when Brody calls everyone in at 02:00 for a kidnapping callout, no one gets paid extra – that's what LEAP is for. Agents grumble about it but don't actually want to give it up.
- GS-14 promotion math. When Brody made SSA, he jumped from probably GS-13 Step 8 or 9 (~\$63K base) to GS-14 Step 1 (~\$60K base) – a small paper cut, but the two-step promotion rule means he likely came in at GS-14 Step 3 or so. The real reason to take the SSA job isn't the money, it's the career trajectory toward ASAC.